Glenn looked at me: ‘I don’t think you’re focused.’

It took me a moment to understand what he’d said.

‘How can you think that? How can you think I’m not focused for the biggest soccer competition in the world? I’m not thinking about anything else. How could I be?’

It wasn’t until later that I found out what was probably behind it all. The previous week, we’d had a day off to relax, play golf, see our families, and do whatever we wanted. Most of the lads had gone out on the course. I’m not much of a golfer and, anyway, any chance I get I want to be with my family. Victoria flew out to France for the day and the two of us spent our time around the apartment complex swimming, sunbathing and catching up. Glenn didn’t like that. The other players were on the golf course. And I wasn’t. So that meant I wasn’t concentrating on England, as far as he was concerned. *They’re all playing golf and he’s with his girlfriend: that can’t be good for team spirit.*

It made no sense to me at all and I still don’t really understand it. If he wanted us all to be together and thought that was so important, then why give us the choice? Maybe it was another chance to test a player, a chance to test me in particular. But why play those mind games with a 23-year-old—or anybody else in the squad, for that matter—especially if the spirit in the camp was something you thought was important?

As I stood there in the hotel reception, I felt like I’d been cut adrift. I couldn’t let it go.

‘Do you know what? I don’t agree with you at all. I’ve not had a very long career but it feels like it’s all been building towards this tournament. How can you think I’d be coming here worrying about anything else? This is the World Cup. That’s how I feel, anyway. I suppose you’ll do what you want.’

And Glenn did just that. He was leaving me out of the team and, now, he was hurrying off to play golf. He obviously wasn’t interested in anything I had to say. He didn’t care and, I suppose, didn’t need to. It was a cold, cold moment.

‘Well, I just don’t think you’re focused. It’s as simple as that.’

We traveled to Marseille for that opening game and I found myself not